CYBER SAFETY GUY

ANDROID PARENTAL CONTROLS

GOOGLE FAMILY LINK — THE COMPLETE PARENT GUIDE

Google Family Link is a free app that gives parents genuine control over what their child does on an Android phone or tablet. It covers screen time, app access, content, location and purchases — all managed from your own phone.

Here's everything you need to set it up and get it right.

FREE — Google Family Link — no subscription needed

72% — of UK smartphones run Android (Statcounter (2024))

6 — key risk areas Family Link can help control

0 — default limits — nothing is set without you

WHAT GOOGLE FAMILY LINK CONTROLS

Screen Time
Set daily limits per app, total daily caps, bedtime locks and a School Time mode with stricter controls during school hours while still allowing educational apps.

App Control
See every installed app. Approve or block anything before it downloads. Nothing arrives without your knowledge.

Content Filters
Set Google Play content ratings, turn on SafeSearch and control what Chrome can access. Block other browsers entirely.

Location Sharing
See your child's real-time location on a map. Manage which apps can access their location in the device settings.

Purchase Control
Require your approval for every in-app purchase. Set monthly spending limits. Remove saved payment cards.

Activity Reports
Weekly reports show which apps were used and for how long. A useful starting point for conversations, not just rules.

WHY PARENTAL CONTROLS MATTER

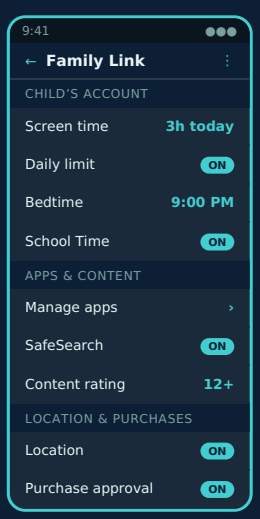
WITHOUT FAMILY LINK — RISKS

- ⚠ No default screen time limits — children self-regulate online, which rarely works.
- ⚠ Any app can be downloaded from Google Play, including age-inappropriate ones.
- ⚠ Explicit content is searchable without SafeSearch being enabled.
- ⚠ In-app purchases can be made using any saved payment card, without approval.
- ⚠ Social apps access location data silently, without you knowing.
- ⚠ No visibility into what your child is doing or how long they spend online.

WITH FAMILY LINK — WHAT YOU CAN DO

- ✓ Set daily screen time limits and automatic bedtime locks from your phone.
- ✓ Approve or block every app before it downloads — nothing arrives unannounced.
- ✓ Turn on SafeSearch and restrict content ratings in Google Play automatically.
- ✓ Require your approval for every purchase and remove saved payment cards.
- ✓ See your child's real-time location and control which apps can access it.
- ✓ Receive weekly usage reports to stay informed without constant monitoring.

SETTING IT UP — STEP BY STEP



STEP 1 — DOWNLOAD
Get Google Family Link
Download the free Google Family Link app on your own phone from the App Store or Google Play. This is the parent app — everything is managed from your side.

STEP 2 — LINK
Connect your child's account
Open Family Link, tap Get Started and follow the prompts to link your child's Google account. Under-13s get a supervised account created automatically.

STEP 3 — ACCEPT
Activate on their device
On your child's Android, sign in to their Google account when prompted and accept the supervision request. The device confirms it is now supervised.

STEP 4 — CONFIGURE
Set your limits
Your child's device now appears in Family Link. Set screen time, block unapproved apps, turn on SafeSearch, enable location and purchase approval.

TIP If your child already has an existing Google account, you can add supervision without creating a new one. On your child's device go to **Settings → Google → Parental Controls** to link their existing account to Family Link.

KEY SETTINGS — WHAT PARENTS CAN CONTROL

SCREEN TIME & APP LIMITS

- ▶ Family Link → child's name → Daily Activity → set per-app time limits
- ▶ Daily Limit → set total daily cap across all apps
- ▶ Bedtime → schedule hours when device locks (different for school/weekend)
- ▶ School Time → stricter limits during school hours, educational apps still permitted
- ▶ Manage Apps → block unapproved apps or mark Always Allowed

ⓘ On Android 16+, many controls are also accessible directly under **Settings → Digital Wellbeing** on the child's device.

CONTENT CONTROLS

- ▶ Google Play → Parental Controls → set content rating (9+, 12+, 16+)
- ▶ Family Link → Google Search → turn on SafeSearch
- ▶ Manage → Chrome → set to approved sites only or block entirely

⚠ Block non-Chrome browsers (Firefox, Brave etc) in Apps — content filters don't apply to other browsers

£ IN-APP PURCHASES

- ▶ Manage → Google Play → Purchases → Require approval for all purchases
- ▶ Child's device → Play Store → Settings → Purchase Authentication → Always
- ▶ Remove saved payment cards from child's Google account

ACTIVITY REPORTS

- ▶ Weekly reports sent automatically to your phone via Family Link
- ▶ Shows time spent per app — useful for conversations, not just enforcement
- ▶ View anytime in Family Link → child's name → Daily Activity

LOCATION SHARING

- ▶ Family Link → child's name → Location → toggle on
- ▶ Your child receives a notification — this transparency is intentional
- ▶ Child's device → Settings → Location → App Permissions → set social apps to Denied

ⓘ Talk to your child before switching location on. Children who know they're located are more likely to speak up if something feels wrong.

WHO THEY CAN TALK TO

- ▶ Manage → App Permissions → Contacts → revoke access for unapproved apps
- ▶ Android has no built-in comms limits — control which messaging apps are installed
- ▶ For Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, Discord and WhatsApp — see CSG platform guides at guides.cybersafetyguy.com

CONVERSATION STARTERS & RED FLAGS

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- Which apps do you use most? Show me what they do.
- Have you ever seen anything online that made you feel uncomfortable?
- Do you know what to do if a stranger messages you?
- Is there anything online you wish you hadn't seen?
- If something felt wrong online, would you feel okay telling me?

TIP Tell your child you are setting up Family Link together, not secretly. Children who understand the reason for parental controls are more likely to respect them.

RED FLAGS TO WATCH FOR

- ⚑ Hiding the screen or closing apps quickly when you walk past.
- ⚑ Becoming upset, anxious or withdrawn after being on their phone.
- ⚑ Receiving messages at unusual hours or from unknown contacts.
- ⚑ New "online friends" they won't tell you about or discuss.
- ⚑ Unexplained charges on a linked bank account or payment card.
- ⚑ Spending much more time on their phone than usual, especially at night.

TIP Family Link settings are a starting point, not a solution. Regular conversation matters more than any app.

QUICK CHECK — 5 THINGS TO DO RIGHT NOW

- ☐ Download Google Family Link and link your child's Android account
- ☐ Set a daily screen time limit, bedtime lock and School Time mode
- ☐ Turn on SafeSearch and set a content rating in Google Play
- ☐ Enable location sharing and set social apps to location Denied
- ☐ Turn on purchase approval and remove saved payment cards
- ☐ Block any non-Chrome browsers from the Apps section

QUICK DO'S & DON'TS

DO

- ✓ Set up Family Link together — transparency builds trust.
- ✓ Respond to app requests quickly — delays frustrate children.
- ✓ Praise them when they come to you with something concerning.
- ✓ Review the weekly activity report together, not alone.

DON'T

- ✕ Set up controls secretly without explaining why.
- ✕ Overreact if they show you something worrying — listen first.
- ✕ Rely on Family Link alone — conversation is still the most important tool.

WHERE TO GET HELP

Childline
0800 1111 • childline.org.uk
Free, confidential support for young people 24/7

CEOP (Child Exploitation)
ceop.police.uk
Report online grooming or sexual exploitation

Internet Matters
internetmatters.org
Guides and tools for parents on online safety

More CSG Guides
guides.cybersafetyguy.com
Platform guides, risk guides and parental controls

REMEMBER

Your involvement today helps your child make safer choices tomorrow.

Family Link is a tool, not a solution. The most important thing is keeping the conversation open.

If your child comes to you with something worrying, your reaction in that moment decides whether they come to you again.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE
childline.org.uk
0800 1111
YOU ARE NOT ALONE
We're here for you.